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When a half-season hit of 'DNA' or a heady dose of nostalgia fails to arouse Manchester United fans, that's when you know you've really f***ed up.

[The appointment of Michael Carrick as interim manager](#) at Old Trafford has been greeted with the same indifference that provided the backdrop to the week-long race to the hot seat. Carrick emerged the winner, beating Ole Gunnar Solskjaer in what was largely a toss-up with a double-sided coin.

However United came to the decision, it is perhaps the best of the two outcomes. It could be viewed as [a triumph for tactics over vibes](#). Which *might* be a step forward; it really is hard to tell at Manchester United.

And that wait in itself could become a problem for Jason Wilcox, Omar Berrada, Sir Jim Ratcliffe and whoever else calls the shots at Old Trafford these days. While they are doubtless backslapping each other right now – well done, boys, good process – the fear lingers that the board have set themselves up for another fall.

Because there is a chance that Carrick succeeds. What then?

United's stated aim at the start of this season was a return to the Champions League and, perhaps more because of the ineptitude of others than anything they themselves are doing right, that remains a realistic goal.

[It is likely England will have five teams in the Champions League next season](#). Carrick and [his coaching staff](#) walked into Carrington to take over a side [one point off fifth](#) in the Premier League with – woefully, but handily – absolutely no distractions whatsoever.

If Carrick drags United back to the top table of European football for 2026/27 while stirring Stretford End sentiment, it would not be an unreasonable expectation of the interim boss to have his title changed to something a little more permanent.

And so, most likely, United's doom cycle continues.

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It has been reported that one of Carrick's more appealing qualities to United was his grasp of the temporary nature of his appointment, in contrast to Solskjaer, who hoped to make it impossible for the board to wave him off again in May.

It is damning that restrained ambition may be seen by United as a positive trait, but also understandable. Because INEOS have been here before.

In 2024, it seems they were set on replacing Erik ten Hag, which was the right call. Then, inconveniently, he went and bloody won the FA Cup. New contracts all round.

That, to the surprise of almost no one, proved to be the wrong call, though it is was certainly the

easiest at the time even in the absence of clamour from fans. Have United learned their lesson?

We could find out in May. The fear must be that this United board will simply kick the can down Sir Matt Busby Way before gathering the day after the end of the season to thrash out the way forward. Europe beckons? Carry on, Carrick.

But if United want to be taken seriously again, then Ratcliffe, Wilcox and Berrada have to get serious themselves – and decisive. Carrick may fulfil his brief but the board must still use the time bought by his interim appointment to identify a coach with serious credentials, then lure them to Old Trafford and do whatever preparation necessary for the next manager to hit the ground running.

Can this board pull it off? Their record doesn't inspire confidence. But United simply cannot emerge from a summer in which [Thomas Tuchel, Luis Enrique, Julian Nagelsmann, Xabi Alonso and Carlo Ancelotti may be available](#) under an interim done good.

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